

MANDAR DEODHAR

BACK TO WINNING WAYS
Newly elected MLC Pankaja Munde, Maharashtra CM Eknath Shinde and deputy CM Devendra Fadnavis after the legislative council polls, July 12; inset, Maharashtra Congress chief Nana Patole

certain manner on the ballot paper, which helps reveal cross-voters. The effective strength of the 288-member Maharashtra assembly is down to 274 and, to win, each candidate needed around 23 first preference votes. The 78-member state council has 27 vacancies, including 12 seats nominated from the governor's quota.

The MLCs the BJP got elected include former minister and OBC leader Pankaja Munde, daughter of late party veteran Gopinath Munde; former Pune MLA Yogesh Tilekar; former minister Parinay Fuke, a close aide of deputy chief minister Devendra Fadnavis; Dalit leader Amit Gorkhe; and former minister Sadabhau Khot, who heads the Rayat Kranti organisation. Shinde's Shiv Sena saw former Lok Sabha MPs Bhavana Gawali Patil and Krupal Tumane going past the post. Ajit Pawar's NCP faction also got its two candidates, Rajesh Vitekar and Shivajirao Garje, elected. Speaking to the media after the results, Ajit said his party had 42 votes, but secured 47, meaning five more MLAs had voted for them. A senior BJP leader said what swung things for the party was the way in which the Mahayuti allocated their preference votes.

From the MVA, Pradnya Satav of the Congress secured a second term and Milind Narvekar of the Sena (UBT), a personal assistant of Uddhav, won his maiden election to the upper house. Uddhav was reportedly upset at MVA partner Patil of the PWP—who was being backed by Sharad Pawar's NCP—for not working for Sena candidates Sanjog Waghere and Anant Geete. So, Thackeray fielded Narvekar, who has friends across party lines, as a candidate. His presence put paid to Patil's hopes of becoming an MLC.

A day before the election, senior Congress MLA Kailash Gorantyal had indicated that three to four party votes could go the other way. Though he didn't take names, Gorantyal hinted that the recalcitrant MLAs could be Zeeshan Siddiqui (Vandre East), whose father and former minister Baba Siddiqui quit the Congress and joined Ajit's NCP; Sulabha Khodke (Amravati), whose husband Sanjay Khodke is an NCP strategist; Hiraman Khoskar (Igatpuri) and Jitesh Antapurkar (Degloor), who is close to former CM Ashok Chavan, now with the BJP. A Congress MLA said that three other MLAs who cross-voted included "surprising" names. He claimed the legislators had been coerced to switch sides.

THE SETBACK TO THE MVA IN THE LEGISLATIVE COUNCIL POLLS SHOWS THE DISCORD WITHIN. CROSS-VOTING CONGRESS MLAs MAY DEFECT TOO

There were reported differences of opinion between the SS(UBT) and the Congress over the allocation of votes to Narvekar. Later, sharp words were reportedly exchanged between Patil's nephew and a senior Sena leader. A displeased Thackeray apparently told a Congress leader that if his candidate met with resistance from within the alliance, there was no point in his staying on. Much of the friction was over Patil's defeat. Patil alleged that one vote of the NCP (SP) had also gone elsewhere and that the sole Communist Party of India (Marxist) MLA had voted elsewhere—a charge denied by both. Patil also cited rumours that the errant MLAs were bribed. Ashish Shelar of the BJP claimed that two SS(UBT) MLAs had cross-voted.

State Congress chief Nana Patole has vowed to take action against those breaching party discipline, and Jitendra Awhad of the NCP(SP) called on voters to teach a lesson to turncoats. The choice of Satav upset some Congress leaders, who wanted a Muslim leader to be nominated, considering that the community voted en masse for the party in the LS polls.

The events evoke a sense of deja vu. In June 2022, a similarly rancorous election to the legislative council—where massive horse-trading led to the defeat of Dalit leader Chandrakant Handore of the Congress—had set off a chain of events that led to the fall of the Uddhav Thackeray-led MVA government. ■